

ANI

substantially between 2018 and 2021. Economic disparity had widened that gap—those who had access to technology moved ahead, while students from underprivileged backgrounds fell behind. All of which made the implementation of the National Education Policy (NEP), announced in 2020, even more urgent. The education ministry says the new curriculum framework will be ready by next year. The government's attempts to 'rationalise' course content, meanwhile, has sparked widespread furore.

But that isn't where the challenge lies. The bugbear is in the execution. While budgetary allocation for the ministry has jumped by more than Rs 8,000 crore or 8 per cent over the previous year, core to NEP's implementation are the country's teachers and we just don't have enough trained teachers. That truth was reiterated in a recent report of a parliamentary standing committee, which stated that more than 980,000 teaching positions out of the over 6.2 million sanctioned posts lie unfilled in state government schools in India. And we are not even talking of proxy teachers. Worse, over 740,000, or 75 per cent, of these vacancies are at the elementary level (Classes 1 to 8), which is key to the foundational learning of students. The committee had other depressing findings—258 Kendriya Vidyalayas (KVs) do not have permanent buildings and are functioning out of temporary accommodations. The committee, in fact, urged the ministry to persuade the state governments to provide land for the KVs. The PM Poshan scheme, earlier known as the mid-day meal scheme, is also facing slow starvation—no independent assessment has been carried out between 2020 and 2023. And what we do not know, we cannot amend.

In fact, education being a state subject, Centre-state conflicts have often derailed certain projects. The ministry's plans to upgrade 14,500 government schools across the country under its flagship Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India (PM-SHRI) scheme at a cost of Rs 27,360 crore over five years is one such instance. The standing committee report found that eight non-BJP ruled states—Bihar, Delhi, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Kerala, Odisha, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal—have still not signed an agreement with the Union government for PM-SHRI schools.

The higher education sector has seen some movement, primarily the introduction of a common university entrance test (CUET) for college admissions, as well as the system of academic credit, under which post-graduates can pursue doctorates, without the earlier mandatory requirement to teach in central universities. Autonomous colleges are now allowed to offer online degrees and foreign universities have been given guidelines if they want to set up a campus in India. While most of these steps are in sync with the NEP, here too the crisis lies in finding manpower—more than 6,000 teaching posts lie vacant in central universities. Other things await action too. Like freeing the National Assessment and Accreditation Council from allegations of malpractices. ■

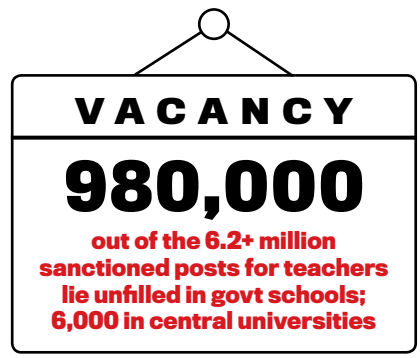
BOLD & BRAVE

- Launched National Education Policy, 2020
- Introduced CUET or the common university entrance test for college admissions



Minimum age fixed for admission to Class 1

BUT...



- Expenditure on education far short of NEP target of 6 per cent of GDP

258
KENDRIYA VIDYALAYAS
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